

Scotland: North Coast 500 & Links Golf

Ten days in the far north of Scotland: seven riding days around the North Coast 500 and the Cairngorms, and three days of links golf at Castle Stuart, Royal Dornoch and St Andrews, the home of golf.

10 days: 7 riding, 3 golf · **Riding:** about 700 miles (1,130 km) · **Start:** Inverness · **Finish:** St Andrews / Edinburgh
· **Best:** May to September · **Drive on the left**

Arrive Inverness

Fly into Inverness (via London or Amsterdam). Collect the bikes and walk the River Ness in the long northern evening light.

Overnight: Inverness

Day 1 Golf at Castle Stuart

Castle Stuart Golf Links on the Moray Firth, ten minutes from Inverness Airport: wide fairways, cliff-top views and an easy first round to shake off the jet lag.

Overnight: Inverness

Day 2 Inverness to Torridon

About 115 miles (185 km)

West through Achnasheen to Lochcarron, then the big one: the Bealach na Bà, a single-track pass climbing to 626 m with hairpins and gradients up to 20% before dropping to Applecross. Lunch at the Applecross Inn, then the coast road north around the peninsula to Shildaig and Torridon.

By way of: A835 · Achnasheen · Lochcarron · Bealach na Bà · Applecross · Shildaig

Overnight: Torridon

Day 3 Torridon to Ullapool

About 90 miles (145 km)

Glen Torridon to Kinlochewe, then along Loch Maree, often called the most beautiful loch in Scotland. Gairloch, Inverewe Garden at Poolewe and the Gruinard Bay viewpoint, then over to Ullapool on Loch Broom, stopping at Corrieshalloch Gorge.

By way of: Kinlochewe · Loch Maree · Gairloch · Poolewe · Gruinard Bay · Corrieshalloch Gorge

Overnight: Ullapool

Day 4 Ullapool to Durness

About 110 miles (175 km)

The wildest day: Assynt's single-track roads past Stac Pollaidh and Suilven, the coast road from Lochinver through Drumbeg (narrow and steep, take it slowly), the Kylesku Bridge, Scourie and on to Durness on the north coast. Smoo Cave is a short walk from the road.

By way of: Stac Pollaidh · Lochinver · Drumbeg · Kylesku Bridge · Scourie · Laxford Bridge

Overnight: Durness

Day 5 Durness to John o' Groats

About 100 miles (160 km)

East along the north shore around Loch Eriboll to Tongue and Bettyhill, with white beaches below the road. Thurso, then Dunnet Head, the true northern tip of mainland Britain, and the signpost at John o' Groats.

By way of: Loch Eriboll · Tongue · Bettyhill · Thurso · Dunnet Head

Overnight: John o' Groats or Wick

Day 6 John o' Groats to Dornoch

About 75 miles (120 km)

South down the east coast past Wick, the Whaligoe Steps, Helmsdale and Brora into Dornoch, a small cathedral town with one of the world's great links on its doorstep.

By way of: Wick · Whaligoe Steps · Helmsdale · Brora · Golspie

Overnight: Dornoch

Day 7 Golf at Royal Dornoch

A round on the Royal Dornoch Championship Course. For a second round, the Struie course next door, or Brora and Tain a short ride away.

Overnight: Dornoch

Day 8 Dornoch to Braemar

About 120 miles (195 km)

Back through Inverness and into the Cairngorms on the "Snow Roads": the A939 over the Lecht to Tomintoul, past Speyside distilleries, then down to Braemar on Royal Deeside.

By way of: Inverness · Grantown-on-Spey · Tomintoul · The Lecht · Cock Bridge

Overnight: Braemar

Day 9 Braemar to St Andrews

About 95 miles (155 km)

South over the Cairnwell Pass at Glenshee, the highest main road in Britain at 670 m, down to Blairgowrie, then east to the coast past Carnoustie and across the Tay to St Andrews.

By way of: Glenshee · Cairnwell Pass · Blairgowrie · Carnoustie · Tay Road Bridge

Overnight: St Andrews

Day 10 Golf at St Andrews

A round on the Old Course (tee times through the ballot) or the New, Jubilee or Castle courses, and a walk over the Swilcan Bridge. Return the bikes in Edinburgh, about 90 minutes south.

Overnight: St Andrews

Depart Fly home from Edinburgh

Edinburgh Airport is about an hour from St Andrews.

Best time to go

- Best: mid-May to late June. Long days (light until after 10 pm in the north), the driest weather of the year in the Highlands, and fewer midges and camper vans than in high summer.
- Good: September. Quieter roads after the school holidays and golf courses in good shape, but shorter days and more rain.
- Busiest: July and August. School holidays fill the NC500 with camper vans, single-track roads slow down, and midges are at their worst.
- Avoid St Andrews around The Open: the 155th Open is at St Andrews July 11–18, 2027, and the Old Course is closed to visitors for several weeks around it.

Riding notes

- Much of the west and north is single-track road with passing places: pull in to let others pass and wave thanks.
- The Bealach na Bà is not suited to a heavy bike in bad weather; the coast road is a lower alternative into Applecross.
- Fuel is sparse in the far north-west. Fill up in Ullapool, Lochinver and Durness.
- Midges are worst in still, damp weather from June to August; bring repellent.

Golf

- Castle Stuart Golf Links, near Inverness
- Royal Dornoch Championship Course (also Struie, Brora and Tain nearby)
- St Andrews Links: Old Course by ballot; New, Jubilee and Castle courses bookable ahead
- Carnoustie is on the Day 9 route if you want a fourth round

Bike rental

- Confirm a one-way rental from Inverness to Edinburgh, or plan an extra riding day back to the pickup point.

Draft route. Distances and times are approximate; check road, pass and ferry conditions before each day.